



Two days for a game

Inside a 48-hour battle to build the best video game
<http://bit.ly/wbGdBd>

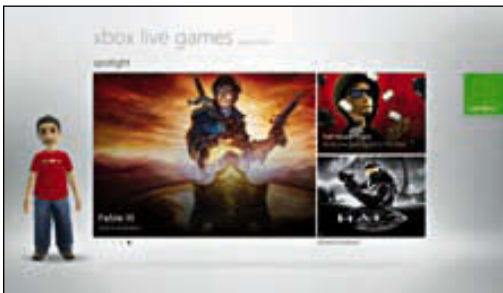
HP Web Services

HP is poised to launch an Amazon Web Services competitor, leveraging its Next Generation Information Platform (NGIP) <http://dgit.in/GEIJkf>

tive at times. Microsoft would do a huge favour to itself and its users by allowing an option for users to determine which “version” or flavour of Windows 8 they’d like to use. If left unchecked, this has the potential to cause a hue and cry like the one witnessed on Vista’s autocratic UAC. Anyone remember those days? Let’s hope they never come back.

Xbox integration

Apart from the general buzz surrounding Windows Phone, the Xbox business has been solid for Microsoft since the past few years, and user interest has rekindled with Kindle’s launch. Times haven’t been better for Microsoft’s Xbox division and it was only logical for the company heavily integrate gaming as an entertainment option within Windows 8.

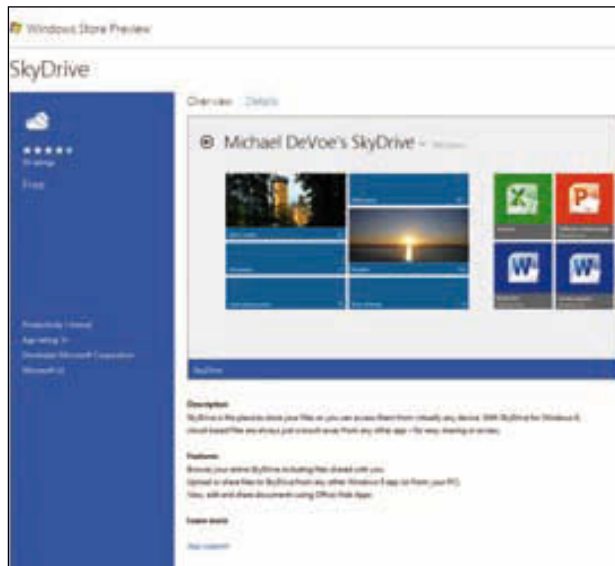


Xbox integration is a great hit in Windows 8

The Xbox Live interface within Windows 8 has a heavy dose of Metro and looks really slick. Whether you hook a Kinect to your PC or manipulate it using your Windows Phone, we can see how Xbox will be an entertainment hub for future Windows users. The platform is hugely popular with millions of subscribers, and Microsoft will no doubt populate it with enough content to take on the likes of Amazon and iTunes. It has huge potential.

SkyDrive

Starting with Windows 8, you get to back up and sync your personal data on the



SkyDrive is Microsoft’s attempt to bundle free cloud backup

cloud. It’s essentially Microsoft’s version of Apple’s iCloud. But there are inherently two apps for SkyDrive which work distinctly. The first is a touch-enabled app found on the Windows Store which allows third-party developers to store Metro and app data onto the cloud drive.

The other version of SkyDrive is deployed across Windows Explorer like Dropbox – share a folder between users on different systems and files added to the folder will be incrementally updated and synced across devices. This feature will work on Windows 7 and Vista PCs as well and the largest file you can transfer using SkyDrive is 2 GB. This is a convenient new addition to Windows 8.

Two different IEs

When Microsoft starts cramming two operating systems into one in Win-

dows 8, that’s when some problems start creeping in. You are left with not one but two different copies of Internet Explorer 10 – one tuned for the Metro UI and touch-enabled navigation, and the other being the classic IE we are all used to in Windows PC.

What’s more, the Metro version of IE10 doesn’t support plugins and has trouble rendering a few Flash websites (we hope this is a beta bug). To view them optimally you’re suggested to open them using the “desktop browser” option, thus compelling you to toggle over to the unrestricted IE10 browser window. We’re sure it works great on a tablet, but we can clearly see how the Metro version of IE10 might become redundant on the PC, if you end up using the desktop version.

Interface tweaks

There are many number of interface tweaks splashed all across Windows 8. Take your mouse cursor to the right side edge to reveal the all new Charms bar – a help pop-up that runs across apps and



It’s literally a tale of two browsers in Windows 8

windows in Windows 8. Also taking the cursor to the left top reveals the previous app, while the left bottom reveals Metro, and if you scroll from top to left along the left edge, we see a list of all running apps right then and there. Great for multi-tasking.

Windows 7’s ribbon interface is muted and will only reveal itself when you press on the top bar. There are a few more features that haven’t made it from Windows 7 to Windows 8. Overall, we feel, Microsoft should allow users the ability to pick and choose which Windows 8 they want to experience, the one tuned for tablets or the good old PC variant. **d**

Windows 8 features

- Metro UI works only on a 1024x768 screen resolution, nothing below that
- The age-old Start button is gone
- Task manager is better, more comprehensive than ever before
- Can upgrade from Windows 7, no Windows XP support.
- Windows Store for downloading apps